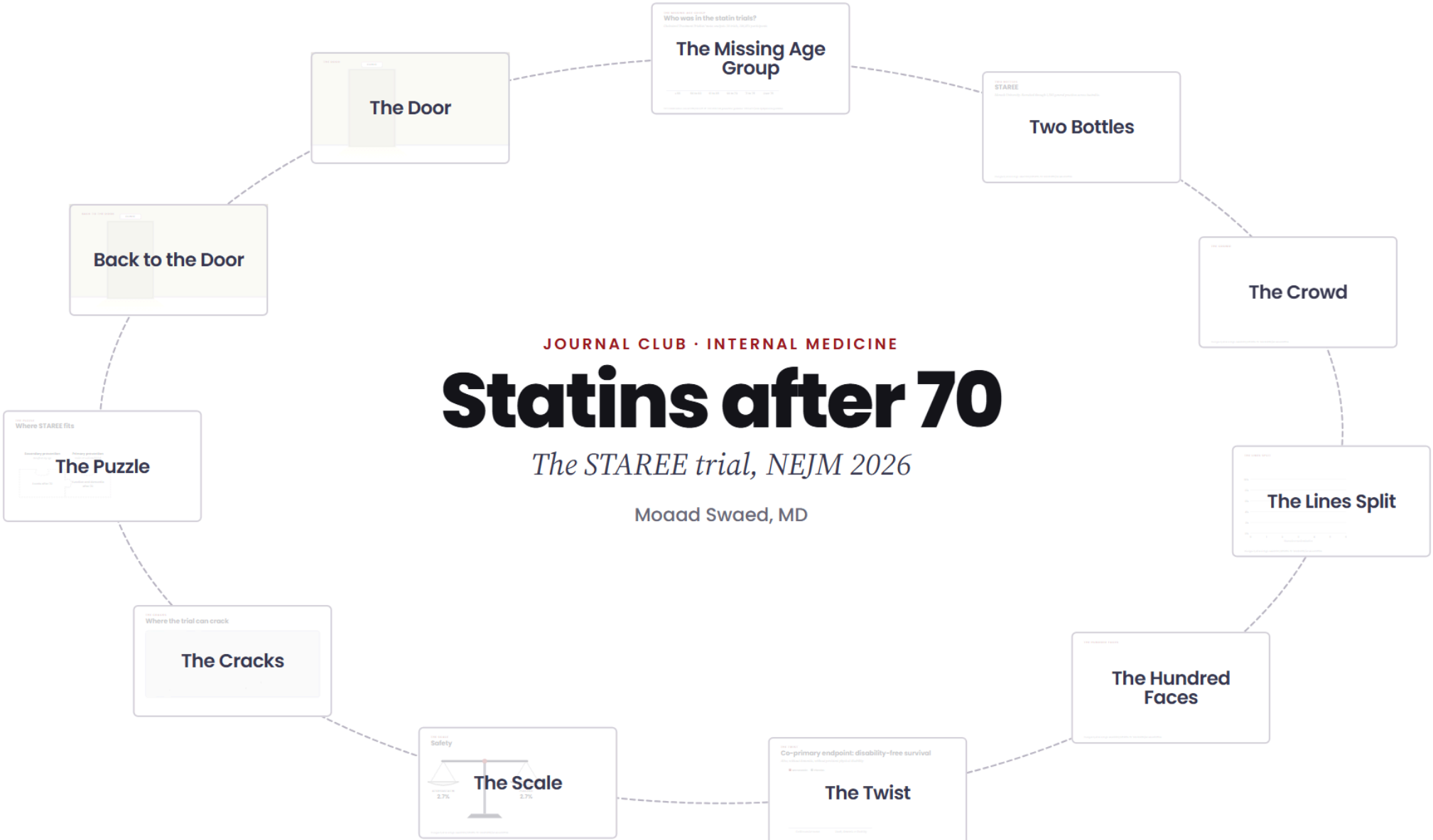
JOURNAL CLUB · INTERNAL MEDICINE

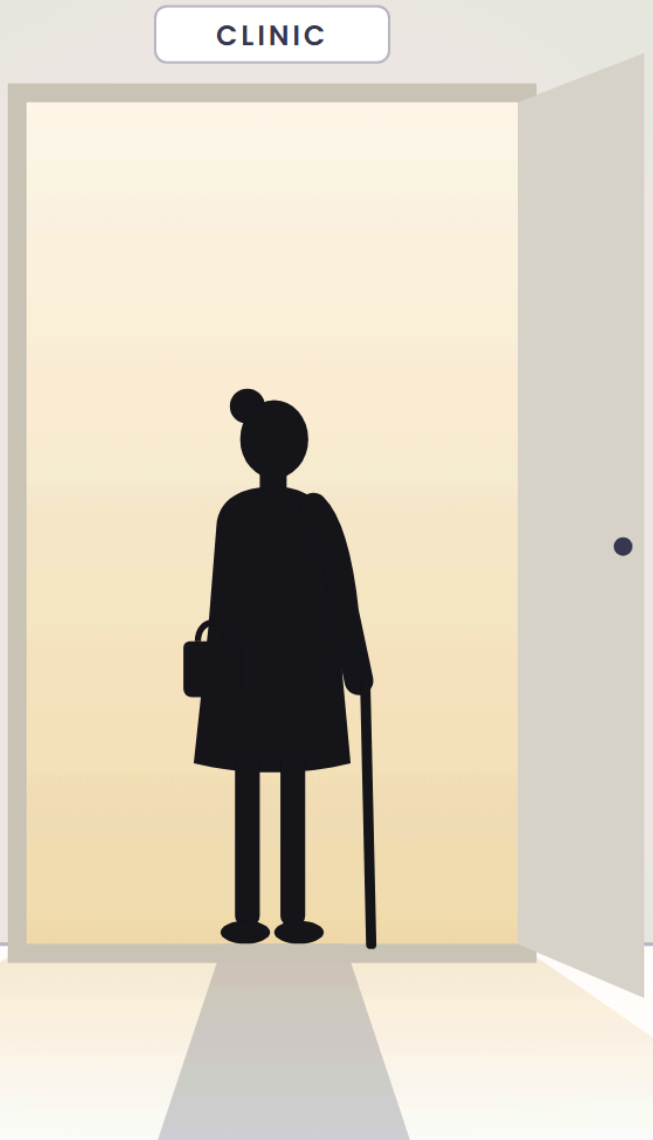
Statins after 70

The STAREE trial, NEJM 2026

Moaad Swaed, MD



THE DOOR



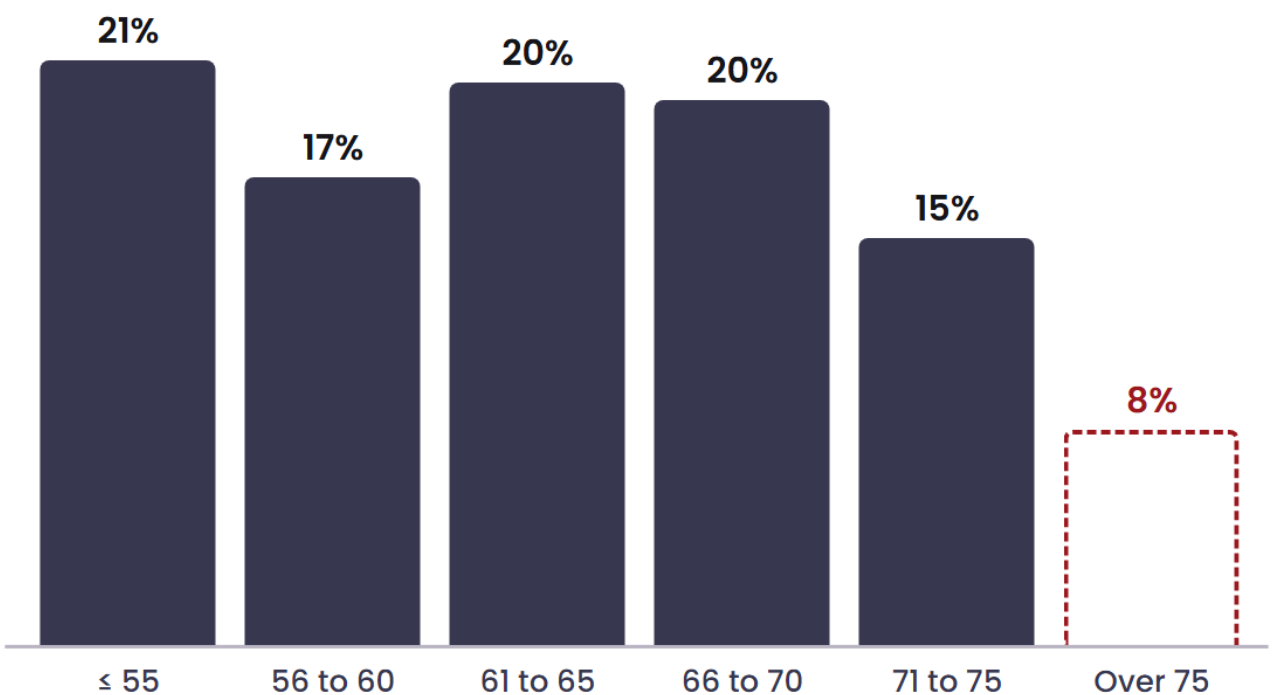
I'm 76 and I feel fine.
Should I start a statin?

76 years old
Lives alone, drives
Walks every morning
Cholesterol a bit high
No heart disease, no diabetes

THE MISSING AGE GROUP

Who was in the statin trials?

Cholesterol Treatment Trialists' meta-analysis: 28 trials, 186,854 participants



Over 75: 14,483 people. 55% of them already had vascular disease.

GUIDELINES BEFORE STAREE

ESC 2021, aged 70 and over IIb

"may be considered"

If at high risk or above. STAREE named as awaited evidence.

ACC/AHA 2026, over 75 2b

"may be reasonable"

If life expectancy is at least 2.5 years, after a discussion.

CTT Collaboration. Lancet 2019;393:407-15 · ESC 2021 CVD prevention guideline · 2026 ACC/AHA dyslipidemia guideline

TWO BOTTLES

STAREE

Monash University. Recruited through 1,583 general practices across Australia.

RANDOMIZED 1 : 1

QUESTION ONE

Does it prevent cardiovascular events?

QUESTION TWO

Does it keep people alive and independent?



4,984

atorvastatin



4,987

placebo

Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

THE CROWD

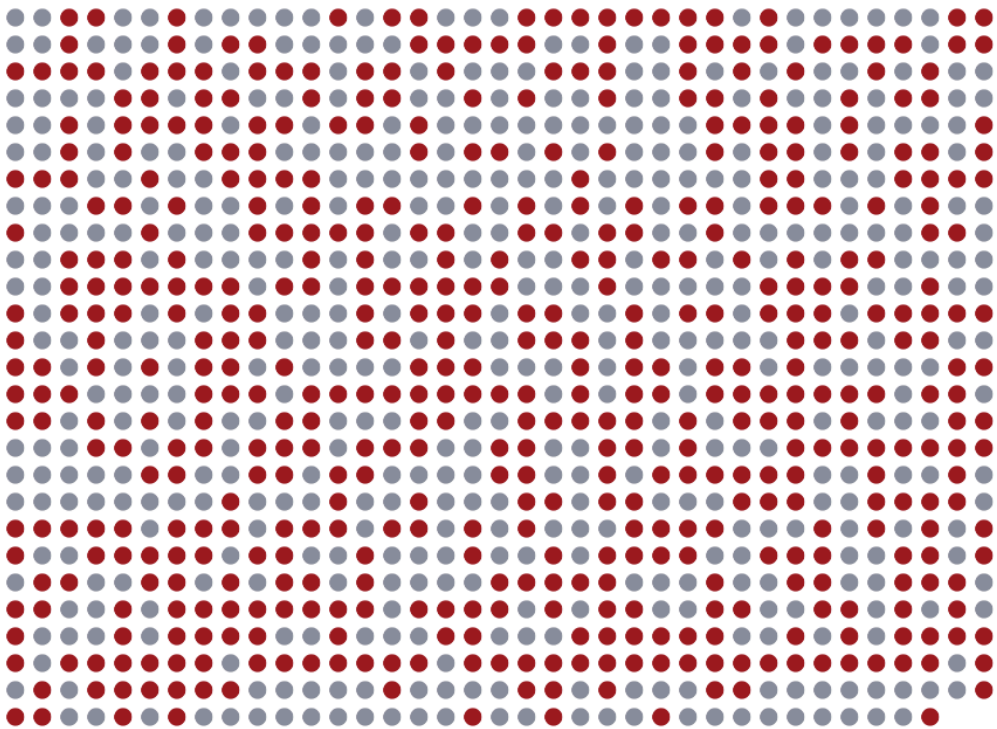
9,971

older adults randomized

- 52% women
- Mean age 74.7
- 40% aged 75 or over

KEEP IN MIND

Healthy, independent people from general practice. Not the frail patients in our beds.



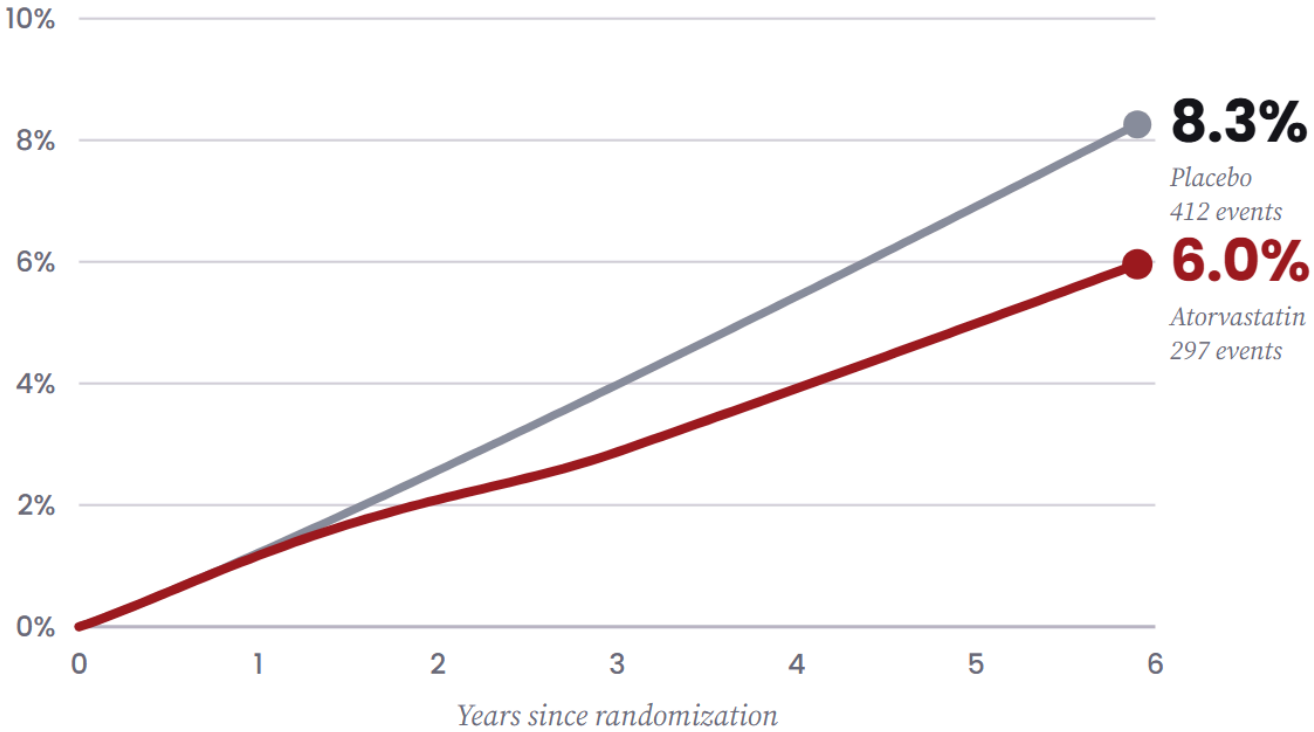
Each dot ≈ 10 participants

Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

THE LINES SPLIT

Primary endpoint: major cardiovascular events

Cardiovascular death | Nonfatal MI | **Stroke** | Coronary revascularization



Illustrative curve shape. End points are trial data: % calculated from published event counts.

HAZARD RATIO

0.70

95% CI 0.61 to 0.82

P < 0.001

30% relative reduction

10.9 vs 15.5 per 1,000 person-years

ONE HONEST NOTE

Stroke alone: HR 0.87 (0.68 to 1.11), not significant. The benefit came from MI and revascularization (each HR 0.57).

Component HRs as reported by Medscape, 29 Aug 2026

Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

THE HUNDRED FACES



WITH ATORVASTATIN 40 MG

6 in 100

have a major cardiovascular event over about 6 years

≈ 2 in 100 spared

NNT ≈ 44 over about 6 years

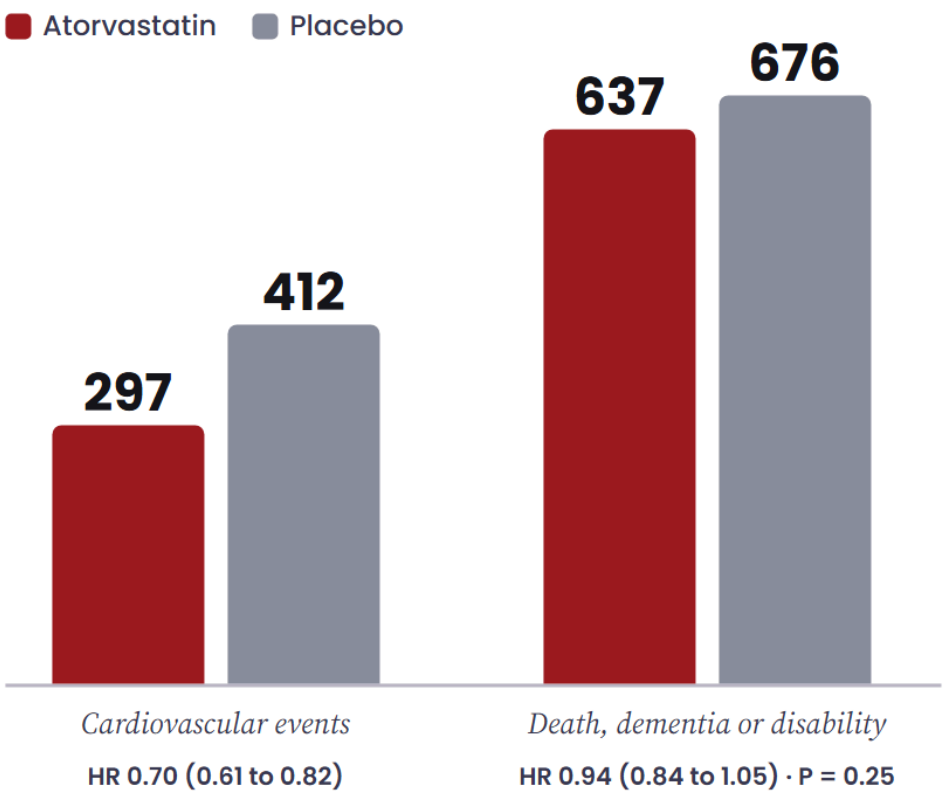
Calculated from published event counts

Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

THE TWIST

Co-primary endpoint: disability-free survival

Alive, without dementia, without persistent physical disability



Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

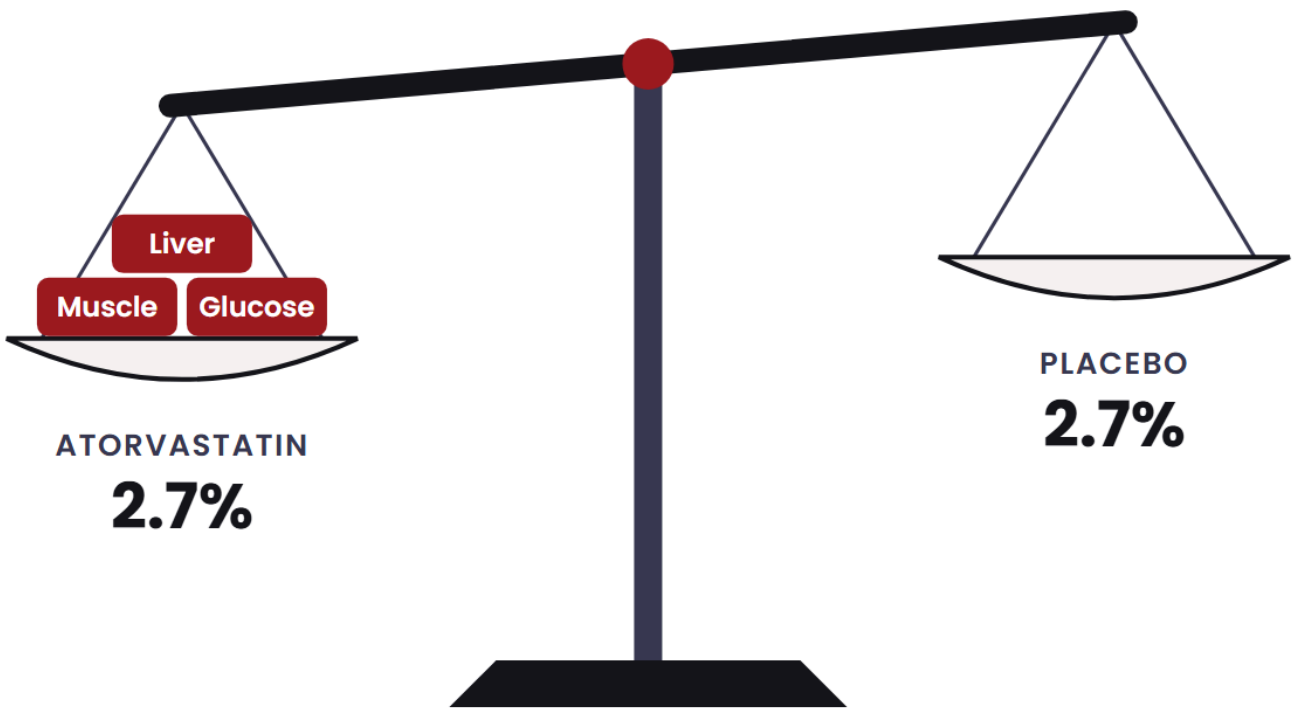
Fewer events ≠ more healthy years

WHY

Competing risks. About 80% of deaths in the trial were not cardiovascular (the authors, ESC 2026).

THE SCALE

Safety



SERIOUS ADVERSE EVENTS

131 (2.7%) vs 129 (2.7%). **No difference.**

MORE WITH ATORVASTATIN

- Musculoskeletal **32.0 vs 29.4%**
- Hepatobiliary **3.3 vs 0.9%**
- New diabetes-related **4.0 vs 2.7%**

The known statin signals. Worth monitoring, not fearing.

Categories: NEJM abstract. Percentages as reported by TCTMD, 29 Aug 2026.

Zoungas S, et al. N Engl J Med 2026;395:1259-72 · DOI 10.1056/NEJMoa2607314

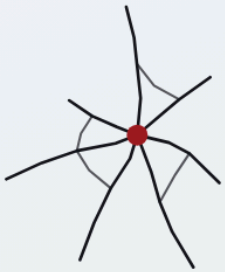
THE CRACKS

Where the trial can crack



Healthy volunteers

Independent people from general practice. Not the frail 85-year-old in bed twelve.



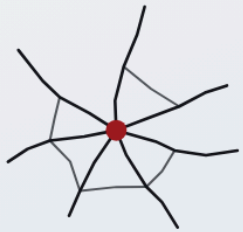
One drug, one dose

Atorvastatin 40 mg, titrated from 20 mg. Other statins and doses are extrapolation.



What drove the benefit

MI and revascularization drove the benefit. Stroke and CV death did not move. Revascularization was added to the endpoint mid-trial.



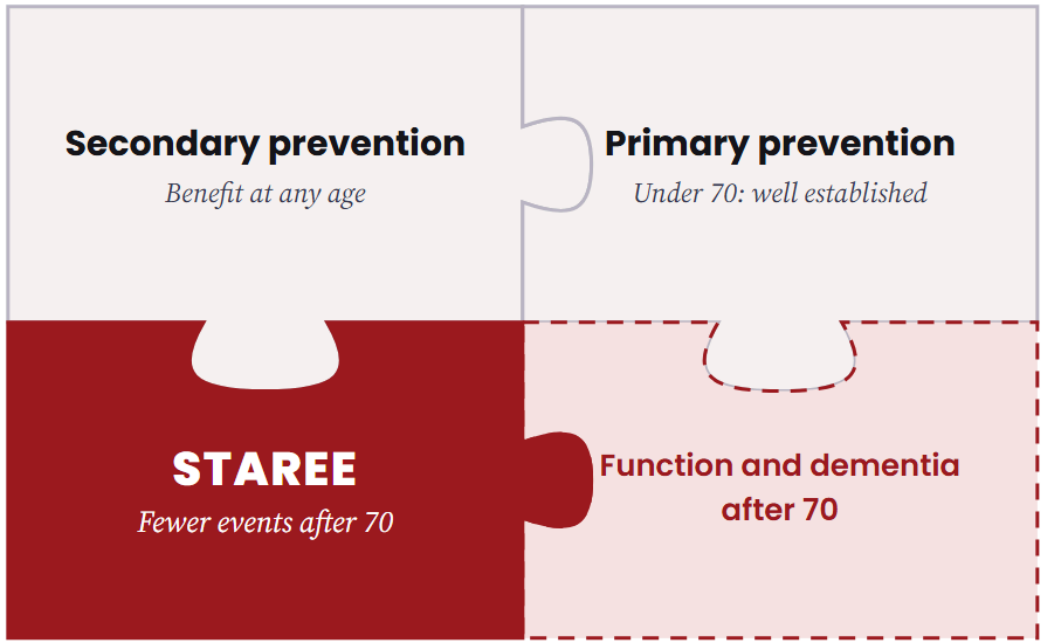
One population

An Australian population, 98% White. Reasonable to apply here, not proven.

And it tested starting a statin, not stopping one.

THE PUZZLE

Where STAREE fits



Until now, statins after 70 rested on extrapolation and subgroups.

STAREE ANSWERS DIRECTLY

First large primary-prevention trial dedicated to people over 70. Fewer events.

STILL MISSING

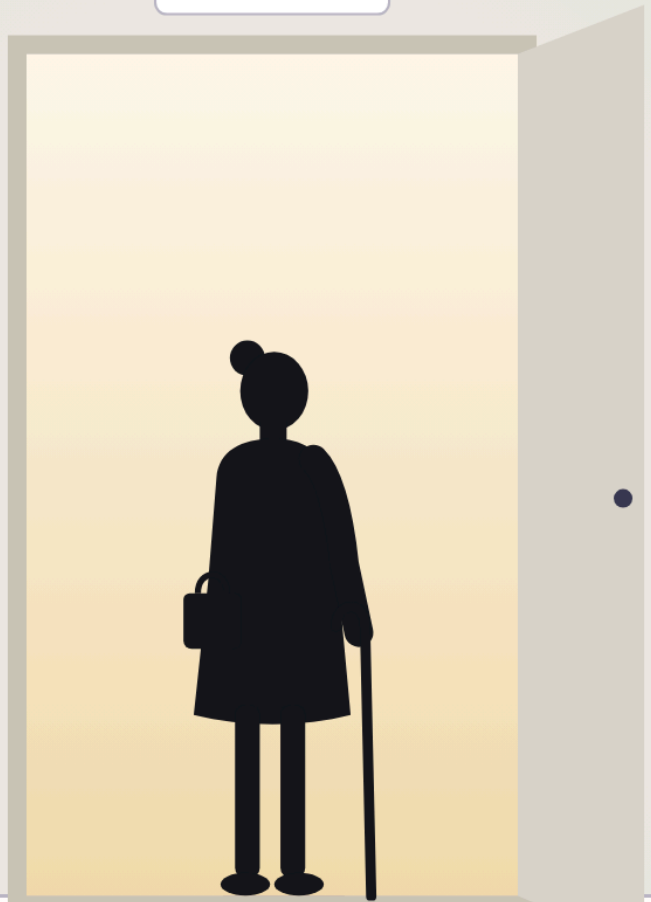
Function and cognition: no gain shown.

MY READING

Guidelines will likely strengthen event prevention after 70, with shared decision-making. Not a guideline yet.

BACK TO THE DOOR

CLINIC



WHAT I TELL HER

Yes, if your goal is fewer heart attacks. This pill lowers that risk.

No, if you hope it keeps you independent longer. It doesn't.

Let's decide together.

FOR US, ON MONDAY

- Robust older patient, no heart disease: a statin is a reasonable offer, including at discharge.
- Frame it as event prevention, not longevity.
- Watch muscles, liver and glucose.

After 70, statins prevent events.
Not decline.

Offer it. Don't oversell it.


The Door
The Missing Age Group
Two Bottles
The Crowd
The Lines Split
The Hundred Faces
The Twist
The Scale
The Cracks
The Puzzle
Back to the Door
After 70, statins prevent events.
Not decline.
Offer it. Don't oversell it.
Thank you. Questions?